



NATIONAL LIBRARY, KOLKATA

A PASS TO THE PAST

"The library's unique contribution is the bibliography that it brings out."

P. T. NAIR, HISTORIAN

TREASURE OF WISDOM: It is the nation's largest library

SUVASHIS MULLICK

A trip to the reading room shows students poring over the books of their choice. The stately white portals invite one to the hallowed premises of the building at the Belvedere Estate in Kolkata. Sprawling across 30 acre, the 172-year-old National Library is a favourite haunt of students and scholars. From rare volumes like *A Grammar of the Bengal Language* (1778) by Nathaniel Brassey, which is the earliest printed book in Bengali, or the 154 letters written by Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose to his family, the nation's largest library is a treasure trove of rare manuscripts, periodicals and newspapers in all Indian languages and English.

The library has its roots in the historic Calcutta Public

Library, which was established in 1836. In 1891, the Imperial Library came into being which was essentially a combination of a number of secretariat libraries of the British Government in India. Later, the two libraries were combined in 1903 and it was formally opened to the public. It was only after Independence that the library was named the National Library and was moved to its present location. "Its unique contribution is the bibliography that it brings out. It is the most authentic document that shows what all is being published in India," says noted historian P.T. Nair. This makes it undoubtedly one of the greatest institutions that signifies the rich cultural and historical identity of India.

by Elora Sen

KERALA KALAMANDALAM, CHERUTHURUTHY STEPPING STONES

Kerala's celebrated art forms like Kathakali, Koodiyattam or Mohiniyattam would not have won universal acclaim if Kerala Kalamandalam had not liberated them from their cloistered feudal settings or traditional temple theatres, which was accessible only to the elite. Set up by nationalist poet Vallathol Narayana Menon in 1930 during the freedom struggle, Kalamandalam was the first to institutionalise India's various traditional classical art forms but had a greater mission as well. "The institution was created to help in the emergence of a national identity, instill pride in our traditions and accelerate the freedom struggle," says Vice-Chancellor K.G. Poullose. Today, Kalamandalam which follows the gurukul tradition boasts of 550 regular students, a 90-member faculty and 30 researchers. The institution also takes pride in the long list of its illustrious alumni that includes Kalamandalam Krishnan Nair, Kalamandalam Gopi and Kalamandalam Ramankutty Nair. It received a fillip last year when UGC recognised it as a deemed university. "We intend to develop as an umbrella organisation with several centres imparting training and research facilities in all the South Asian dance and theatre forms," says Poullose. The institution has not only preserved the art forms but recreated them to suit modern sensibilities as well.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

SHANKAR

STAGE FLIGHT: Poullose at the Kalamandalam campus

